

DOYENS OF DEVOLUTION
Rajiv Gandhi with Mani Shankar Aiyar, who went on to become the first minister of panchayati raj in 2004

PRASHANT PANJIYAR

PANCHAYATI RAJ, 1992

POWER TO THE PEOPLE

Empowering grassroots governance, the 73rd and 74th Amendments to the Indian Constitution redefined democracy, ushering in local self-rule and inclusivity

BY KAUSHIK DEKA

By the late 1980s, India's political structure was grappling with systemic challenges. Development programmes launched in the name of rural upliftment were floundering, stymied by inefficiencies, corruption and a glaring disconnect between policy and the grassroots. Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs), envisioned in Article 40 of the Directive Principles, were largely symbolic entities, hamstrung by irregular elections, inadequate financial powers and captured by the elite. The urban landscape was equally fragmented, with municipalities undermined by state interference, fiscal insolvency and ad-hoc governance.

Rajiv Gandhi, buoyed by a massive electoral mandate in 1984, sought to change that. The Panchayati Raj and Nagar Palika Bills, finally introduced in 1989, proposed constitutional status to PRIs and urban local bodies (ULBs), ensuring regular elections, reservations for marginalised groups and financial devolution. However, the political turbulence of the late '80s, includ-

DID YOU KNOW?

The Ministry of Panchayati Raj has signed MoUs with six IIMs, IIT Dhanbad and IRMA for conducting leadership/management development programmes for elected representatives of PRIs. So far, 193 participants, including 38 women, have been trained